

"the" & "a"

"The" & "A" - A vs. an

A Quick-Reference Guide

Rule:

AN -> the sound of a vowel

A -> for the sound of a consonant (or not a vowel)

Note 1:

Not a vowel or consonant in spelling, but the **sound**.

- She has an MBA. [Em-b-ei]
- He has a one track mine. [Wan trak]
- It will last for an hour. [a-wer]

Note 2:

Pronunciation changes over time & Space, so some phrases are sometimes used with the old pronunciation, e.g.

- (British English) She has a herb. [Herb]
- (American English) She has an herb. [erb]

The main phrase that people vary on is "an historic(al)":

- (Older English) It was an (h)istoric occation. ['istoric]
- (Newer English) It was a historic occation. [historic]

Both uses are used in most English speaking countries.

(Source: Oxforddictionaries.com)

Note 3:

While "Y" sometimes is or behaves like a vowel, in this case "Y" is a consonant, which can apply to vowels such as "U."

- We went for a yearly exam. [yeerly]
 - She made a useful suggestions. [yoos]
- vs. - It was an uber-big mistake. [oober]

Examples:

a flee,
a total,
a fish,
a year,

an egg,
an orange,

A: b,c,d,g,j,k,p,q,t,w,x,y,z

An: a,e,f,h,i,l,m,n,o,r,s,

A: 1,2,3,4,5,6,7,9,10,12,13

An: 8,11,18,80